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Nature, landscapes, and textures come alive at Chennai Photo Biennale’s exhibit **P2**

IPL 2026: YELLOW FEVER GRIPS CITY **P4**

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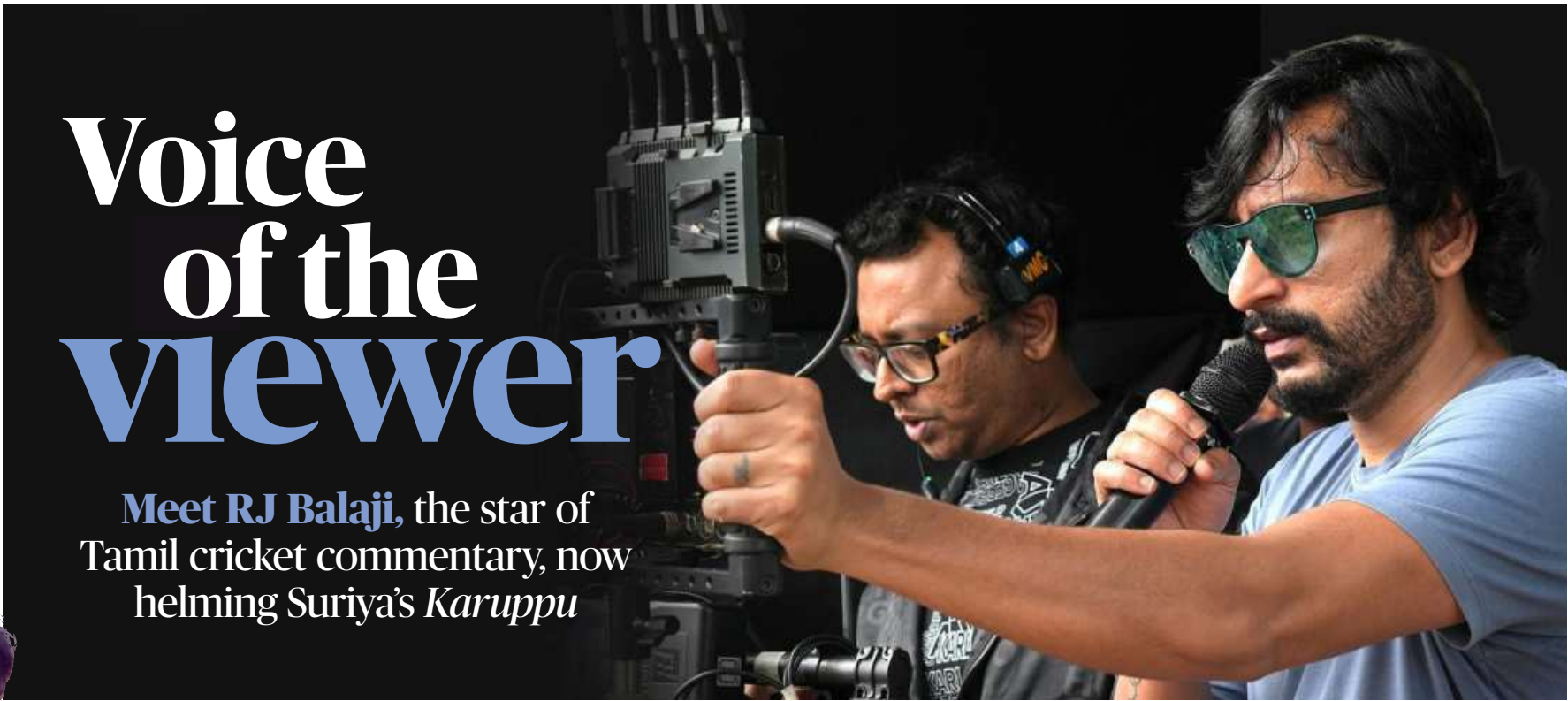
Balaji sits at the cross-section of pop culture, films and cricket. As a leading radio jockey-turned-actor-turned-director, he is steeped in Tamil cinema references. As an enthusiastic sportsman, having played cricket for a local team called Venus 11 when he was young, he understands Chennai’s street-cricket culture.

This is reflected when he sits on the commentary panel of Star Sports Tamil. His vibrant delivery represents the ebb and flow of a viewer’s mind during the course of a thrilling match; it is a big change from the more demure rhythm associated with English cricket commentary over the decades. During the recent T20 World Cup, which India won, and with the upcoming IPL, Balaji makes a grand comeback to Tamil commentary



Voice of the viewer

Meet RJ Balaji, the star of Tamil cricket commentary, now helming Suriya’s *Karuppu*



after a gap of two years - during which he was directing his upcoming film, *Karuppu*, starring Suriya and Trisha. “I realised how much I missed this medium. A shooting

spot is usually very stressful as it involves managing a big team of people and comes with the responsibility of helming big stars. My absolute mad energy was at its peak when I used to host my radio show and now, it is during cricket commentary. It’s a strong spiritual connection between live media and me,” says Balaji. He does not just add humour to your cricket evenings. He infuses an

infectious energy to supplement the adrenaline-filled sporting moments. What is it about Tamil commentary that has clicked with the masses? “Earlier, the man of the house used to own the TV remote during a cricket match. Today, I see elderly women following the sport, because it is spoken about in a language they are comfortable in, with references that they understand. Along with the

rise of the IPL, regional commentary has democratised the sport,” he explains. “Today, we watch a CSK match in the IPL, just the same way we watch a *Super Singer* show or a *Ghilli* on a Sunday evening.” Balaji’s popularity as a cricket commentator has also been opening doors in unexpected places. “When I was doing my film *Mookuthi Amman*, I wanted to shoot in a particular house, but the

elderly lady who owned the place was reluctant to give it out for film shoots. She was 87. But when she saw me, she recognised me from commentary and immediately gave us the go-ahead.” Not everyone likes Balaji. Many traditional cricket viewers, who have been following the sport for decades, disapprove of his eccentricities in the commentary box. “I am signed up to represent the common

Run fest RJ Balaji on the sets of *Karuppu*; and (far left) during cricket commentary. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

viewer and not please the purists,” he adds.

Frames and games Balaji also loves being on sets. Today, he is an established filmmaker - his big-ticket Suriya-starrer *Karuppu* is set to release on May 14. “As a director, this film is 15 times bigger in scale from my previous flick.” It helped that he was surrounded by a strong technical team – GK Vishnu handles the camera, Vikram Mor helms stunts while Sai Abhyankar takes charge of the music. “Suriya sir is a superstar but makes you feel like he is the newcomer,” recalls Balaji. “*Karuppu* is a solid, commercial film that will cater to the entire family. If you have watched Tamil cinema in the last decade, heroes are largely playing either a rowdy, goon, don or a cop. It’s like there are no other professions. The heroes I grew up watching were either a milkman, a tea shop owner, teacher or a driver, doing everyday jobs. *Karuppu* will feature elements of those movies we adored in the past, but with a strong social message, because I feel that there has to be some takeaway from a film.”


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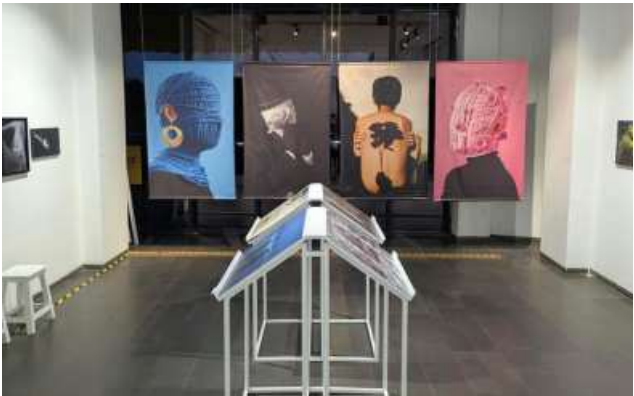
Walk past OSR Park in MRC Nagar, and one is transported on an unexpected journey – one that moves from the mangroves of the Sundarbans to the peat-rich bogs of Ireland, from the industrial scars of the Western Balkans to distant, shifting terrains across continents. Part of the second edition of the International Photography Open Call showcase, organised by Chennai Photo Biennale, this open-air exhibition unfolds not just here but across VR Chennai, and Avatar Foundation for the Arts, MRC Nagar, bringing together a global visual conversation.

Selected from 9,400 submissions across 37 countries, over 100 photographs on display traverse intimate and political terrain. In MRC Nagar, photographer Swastik Pal captures life in the Sundarbans, where severe climate change has brought humans and wildlife into closer contact. Shane Hynan's Beneath Beofhod reflects on Ireland's boglands as sites of memory and restoration, while Mateo Trevisan's More than the Sun examines the impact of coal-driven industrialisation in the Western Balkans.

Sugandha Garg's series Littleness, consisting of pinhole photographs, invites

Chennai Photo Biennale transforms OSR Park, VR Chennai, and Avatar Foundation for the Arts into a citywide gallery of stories, landscapes, and lived realities

A global snapshot



viewers to reflect on notions of space, freedom, and invisible boundaries that shape modern life.

"I love the idea that you can be walking down a street, glance to your right and suddenly encounter a work someone has spent a decade creating... there's something deeply democratic about that moment of chance, where art quietly enters everyday life, opening up the world in

the most unexpected ways," says Sugandha.

Open to all
The artworks are selected by a panel of photographers, visual artists, and filmmakers like Ashfika Rahman, Avani Rai, Kaamna Patel, Bharat Sikka, whose expertise brought a non-linear approach to the exhibition. "One of the criticisms we faced at the Biennale was, 'How do I

participate – where do I show my work?' The open call was our answer: a space where anyone could submit without the pressure of a theme," says Varun Gupta, founding director, Chennai Photo Biennale Foundation.

In VR Chennai, the single-image showcases are presented both physically and digitally, taking viewers through the streets and bazaars of India, into homes, to beaches, and across diverse landscapes.

At Avatar Foundation for the Arts, visitors can engage with multiple artworks by the same artists. From Kashmir, Jannan Kazmi's series Her Hands are Filled with Stars, created in Makardah, West Bengal, imagines a world where women can freely occupy public spaces at night. Here, women are seen outdoors after dark – walking, gathering, and simply

existing under the open sky. "I have grown up in Kashmir, in not a very conservative but definitely a very protective family. The idea began when I started stepping out at night. I noticed that there were hardly enough women in the streets... and what it would feel like to feel safe enough to be out. It became about imagining how we might reclaim these spaces, in the end, it turned into an act of rebellion," says Jannan. The photographs showcased are part of the international photography programme at Pathshala South Asian Media Institute, hosted by Bangladesh at Anandi Foundation, Makardah.

"One of the best things about open call is that photography isn't limited to those represented by galleries or what we call 'high art'. These are people who've simply made submissions. So really, it's about coming in, experiencing it, and recognising that art can be made and enjoyed by everyone," says Jaiveer Johal, arts patron and founder, Avatar Foundation for the Arts.

Among the other photographs is a series by Stephanie Lee from Singapore, titled Your Favourite Disappointment, that shows how an illness reshapes a strained relationship between a father and daughter. Then there are British Traditions by Leah Gordon from UK, a black and white series showing dancers in costume, figures disguised as animals, and processions that echo the centuries-old beliefs of the country.

Through the photographs, the second edition becomes a space where climate anxieties, cultural memory, intimacy, and resistance intersect, dissolving the boundaries between art and audience.

The second edition of the International Photography Open Call showcase is on till April 5, at VR Chennai, Avatar Foundation for the Arts, and OSR Park.

The science symphony

Science at the Sabha returns with talks by eminent scientists that make complex ideas easy to understand, from neutron stars to AI



A full sabha A session in progress during the last edition of the event in 2025. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Have questions about science kept you up at night?

Sure, it might be fun to scroll for answers online, but the Institute of Mathematical Sciences (IMSc) has a more enriching disquisition at hand. At the ninth edition of Science At The Sabha, the institute will have four talks for the public. You do not need to be a science enthusiast or possess any specialised knowledge to attend.

"Every year, the idea is to invite eminent scientists working in India across various fields and have them talk about the work going on in their labs or research they are interested in. We want science to be accessible to the general public, and see an audience across a range of ages, from eight to 80 years," says Varuni P, project scientific officer, IMSc.

This year, the sessions begin with Debarati Chatterjee from the Inter-University Center for Astronomy and Astrophysics delving into neutron stars in her talk Gravitational waves: Listening to the Cosmic Symphony. Early developmental processes and behavioural tendencies will take centrestage

in the talk From Fish to Feelings: How Early Life Shapes Who we Become by Amrutha Swaminathan from the Indian Institute of Science Education and Research Thiruvanthapuram.

In S Viswanath's talk on The Secret Lives of Everyday Numbers, the mathematics professor from the Institute of Mathematical Sciences will help the audience discover a 'miraculous algorithm'. Find answers to all your musings about AI and its superhuman abilities in the talk AI-Deus ex Machina?, by B Ravindran from IIT Madras.

Sitabhra Sinha, Professor, Physics and Computational Biology and Dean, Computational Biology PhD programme says, "We strongly believe that apart from doing cutting edge research in science, the science community has a responsibility to speak to the people about their work. There are certain topics that have always held wonder like astronomy for instance and every year, we have a mix of topics that are appealing as well as current," he says.

Science At The Sabha will be held at the Music Academy, on March 29 from 4pm to 8pm. Entry is free with mandatory registration on imsc.res.in/outreach/scisabha/2026.



Lalithalakshmi, R Rajendran, J Rakesh, Rekha Senthoo, Ritu Tripathi, Sudha Rajendran, Tripura, Uma Maheswari A, and Yaser Shajahan. *@Art Space by Kalpa Druma, Gopalapuram, till March 30.*

A canvas of many voices
Ten Chennai-based artists come together for Oviya Tharunangal, a group art exhibition, featuring over 25 artworks, that celebrates artistic diversity, innovation, and visual storytelling. The participating artists are Deepak R, P



Jaya Sahodharan
Organiser, activist

Back in 2014, the National Legal Services Authority v. Union of India (2014) became a landmark judgement of the Supreme Court of India, which declared transgender people the 'third gender', and gave us the right to self-identification of our gender as male, female or third gender. This is after years of being humiliated, shamed, removed from our homes, and being left to fend for ourselves on the streets. The 2014 judgement gave us self-respect. So did late Chief Minister MK Karunanidhi, who bestowed upon us the term 'thirunangai' – respectful woman – instead of the archaic 'aravani'.

Tamil Nadu then progressed, eliminating the need for medical examination to be determined trans. We did not have to ever lift our skirts up to prove who we were. We created welfare boards, joined the Corporation as members of advisory committees, helped secure housing, and started studying, and even working in firms and systems that once rejected us. The change has been slow yet steady in the state. This new Bill fundamentally robs us of dignity and sets us back many years. It makes us existential. "Am I not trans enough under this Bill" it makes us ask. To change that, we will fight.

The Transgender Amendment Bill which was just passed in the Lok Sabha impacts a trans person's ability to access education, health care, and the right to self-determination, say gender-diverse members at a protest this week in Chennai

No space for silence



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V Neela Naik
Jamaat leader

The jamaat system, which has existed for many hundred years, protects trans adults and children who run away from oppressive homes that seek to kill, erase and change us. The Centre though, is now calling us criminals, demonising the system. We do not force any trans kids into begging or sex work. The system does not allow us to do other jobs. It is in rare states like Tamil Nadu where trans education is high. The jamaat is only a safe space, a launchpad for young kids who have nowhere else to go. Choosing to criminalise us under the act without any provisions to provide reservation in terms of education, proper health insurance, better medical support through gender-sensitive doctors, and possibilities of housing, is snatching away all attempts at protection.



Marakkah
Trans Tamil teacher

The Central government wants to tell me what gender I must present as, rewriting Dr. Ambedkar's beautifully constructed Indian Constitution in which Article 21 guarantees that "no person shall be deprived of his life or personal liberty except according to procedure established by law". The amendment is an attempt to rewrite fates on religious lines. This marginalised community has members from the Hindu, Muslim, and Christian community. Some others are atheists.

Whatever gets us through. By imposing Hindu identities like 'aravani' that comes only in the Mahabharata, we lose our ability to choose a faith-neutral term, conforming to a Hindutva narrative. No law can tell me who I am.



Fred
Trans man and activist

The new Bill to amend the The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019 by the Social Welfare Department of India, seems to only recognise 'kinner', 'hijra', 'aravani', 'jogta', eunuchs, and intersex community members. Who then, are trans men? Why does our existence have to be erased? In a patriarchal society like India, the prenatal family tends to be the first space of violence. Here, we are killed, poisoned, and violated. Aravani Conversion therapy is forced on us just because we try to exist as ourselves. The act in 2019 allowed us to exist as ourselves. It gave us recognition. We were invited to be part of the Transgender Welfare Board in Tamil Nadu. This Bill wants to take us back to the status from 20 years ago, where only visibly trans people are recognised. It is going to hinder our everyday. Our identity, invalidated. We will not stand for it.

QUICK CROSSWORD #46 (Set by Doppelganger)

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Across

1 Dairy product (4)
3 Work without assistance (4-4)
9 From breast to waistline (7)
10 Streamlined (5)
11 Idiomatic (5)
12 Nylons (6)
14 Break in (6)
16 Alpine dwelling (6)
19 Throughout (6)
21 Say (5)
24 Chemical compound (5)
25 Impede (7)
26 Choreograph (8)
27 Blackball (4)

Down

1 Beef (8)
2 Wireless (5)
4 Attempt (6)
5 Suspicious (5)
6 Forever (7)
7 Jab at (4)
8 Square away (4,2)
13 Producer of Roe (8)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

Solution No. 46

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Shots and giggles
(Clockwise from left) Karl (centre, in black) with the core team; and food and cocktails at the bar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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A man from Goa sets up a bar in Chennai. This may sound like a plot twist. But for Karl Fernandes – an experienced bartender-turned consultant – who just opened the doors of Roc-A-Coe to Chennai, this seemed like a natural progression.

“I’m an opportunist who looks at markets that are new. There’s a huge audience here that appreciates this whole art of mixology and cocktails. It’s nicer to step out into a less populated world because what you reap is much better,” says Karl. Roc-A-Coe is a modern interpretation of a 1930s cocktail bar. The interiors are dictated by Art Deco influences, symmetry in lines, partitions with quirky posters of cocktails from the late 1920s and ‘30s, and a palette rich in brown, burgundy, grey and pops of teal. Karl who has been part of the F&B industry for 16 years, says he had been studying the Chennai market for two years before setting up shop here. “What surprised him is the spending capacity and the appreciation people have for experiences,” smiles Karl, who has also been associated with Bar Tesouro in Goa, Bar Kin Ru in Hyderabad, and Permit & Co, in Mumbai. While Roc-A-Coe was ready earlier this year, the team wanted to launch it at the same time the overhauled Khader Nawaz Khan Road opened.

Pour decisions welcome

Karl Fernandes’s bar, Roc-A-Coe, pairs Art Deco interiors with a cocktail menu that riffs on Old Madras’ punch houses



There is even a whisky-based drink – Cobbles & Hooch with lime juice and mango ginger cordial – dedicated to the new cobblestone path that

KNK now flaunts. The cocktail menu is divided into three: The first segment named The Vestiges of Old Madras, looks at Madras of yore, opens with Esplanade, First Served, because in the 1700s, Esplanade, in George Town, was where the whole era of drinking houses began. The old pubs were called punch houses then. Given this city’s love for pickles, Karl and his team experimented with pickling techniques for the savoury cocktails. An ode to Madras, they have names like Black Town Bitter Paloma, #11 House Pour and The

Keeper’s Preserve. Ingredients include raw mango brine, *narathangai* cordial, jackfruit, brined plum mix, and coriander. Chennai likes a savoury and sour palate, observes Karl. The other favourite is The Rosette which falls under a section titled: Cool Cups and Dainty Drinks. This gin-based drink has a fragrant, fresh strawberry flavour and is adorned with a white chocolate bread (I could do with more of this). **Bar bites** The food menu is compact, a deliberate move to keep the attention on the cocktails. I get myself beef empanadas – addictive with minced beef, cheese and truffle

oil, though the grey charcoal dip does not do anything for the dish; and bread and butter, the eternal comfort food jazzed up with sourdough bread, gochujang butter and spicy chickpea miso. Chef Anburajakumar from Chennai helms the kitchen and Chef Adrial Branco from Goa is the consulting chef. Although it is 6pm on a busy Tuesday evening, my next pour – from the Modern Art of Polite Drinking segment – makes me feel like I am on vacation on a tropical island. I take a long sip of my boozy dessert cocktail and sway to the swing jazz that plays in the background. The first sip evokes notes of pandan and rum, and eventually custard apple and cream. This is Roc-A-Coe’s take on Pinacolada and I recommend this as much as the Horchata De Masula if you have a sweet tooth like me. At this point, I am ready to call it a night but Karl insists not without trying the drink named after the bar. Roc-A-Coe it is. The bitter sweet symphony of vermouth and sharp, crisp flavours of dry gin blend well to give me a solid kick that makes me stumble back home singing happy songs and channelling my inner Shirley Temple. After all, I am in the 1930s.

Meal for two costs: ₹4,000. For details, call 8925977804. Roc-A-Coe is located at 11, Khader Nawaz Khan Road.

Hola Mexico!

MadCo, Chennai’s intimate speakeasy, will host a Mexican pop up, with a food menu curated by Chef Mathangi Kumar, and experimental cocktails which include a Marigold Highball. Ancho chiles, among the most popular chillies used in Mexican cuisine have been imported and there is a slow cooked beef cheek in the birria chat. Also try the squid karuvad, dried squid on some panko-fried calamari, anda quesarotta stuffed with paneer. Because this is Mathangi’s version of Tex Mex, expect a lot of fiery local flavours as well. There is also fajita chicken stuffed between fluffy fried potato buns, and semolina fried fish on creamy cauliflower puree then topped with gobi 65. For lunch and dinner reservations, DM @madco_chennai on Instagram.





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In 2015, music composer GV Prakash Kumar made his debut as a lead actor in the horror-comedy *Darling* and followed it with the adult comedy *Trisha Illana Nayanthara*. The Prakash we saw in these films was animated and eruptive, in contrast to the timid, soft-spoken composer audiences had known. “Then I abandoned that scale of acting, and I started doing serious films. Comedy is a very risky zone. Which is why many films will either be a blast or a dud; there’s no two ways about it. That is why I had stayed away from it for so long,” says Prakash.

And now, after more than 10 years since *Trisha Illana Nayanthara*, Prakash seems to be returning to that zone in this week’s comedy-drama, *Happy Raj*, directed by debutant Maria Raja Elanchezian. “I watched *Trisha Illana Nayanthara* when I was in college, and the vibe of that film, start to end, was quite something. So I wanted to bring him back in that zone, but in a more family-friendly story,” says Maria. *Happy Raj*’s trailer promises a riotous comedy surrounding the titular character’s romantic escapades and his equation with his father, played by George Maryan.

Prakash chips in to mention how many, like Pradeep

My happy place

Why GV Prakash goes back to his *Trisha Illana Nayanthara* zone with his latest release

Ranganathan, whom Maria assisted, have been fans of *Trisha Illana Nayanthara*. “In fact, Pradeep narrated *Comali* to me after watching that film. I had even suggested a couple of corrections. We were supposed to do that film, but that didn’t fall through. But Pradeep has been in touch with me ever since. Then we had films like *Love Today*, and Vignesh Shivan did *Kaathuvaakula Rendu Kaadhal*; *Trisha Illana Nayanthara* has inspired many such films. And now, Maria has taken the energy of that film and has done a jolly, family-friendly movie.”



Dad’s the way Sri Gouri Priya and GV Prakash Kumar in a still from *Happy Raj*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

As comedy is a risky zone, Prakash was initially sceptical about Maria’s script. “He had worked out the humour quite well, but I wasn’t sure how it would turn out, and so I asked him to shoot a few scenes. He took some of his friends and shot a few scenes on his mobile phone, and it turned out to be phenomenal,” he says, adding, “Audiences will get to see me in a brighter zone again, but at the same time, they will also relate to the emotions.”

The actor adds that the audience will have a pivotal takeaway at the end of the film. “It’s a film dedicated to every single father. It’s a coming-of-age story of a father and a son. It’s about how they understand life in their own ways.”

Having a multi-hyphenate like Prakash has certainly helped Maria in making his debut film. “Being a composer, he knows the beat of the scenes. Whenever he finishes shooting a good scene, he would say, ‘This is a hit. Mark this scene for promos.’ He knows the pulse of the audience.”

In *Happy Raj*, the casting of television personality and YouTuber Adhirchi Arun has turned quite a few heads. Of late, it has become a trend to cast influencers in films to help promotions, but Maria says that wasn’t the case with Arun. “We were searching for someone to play this role, and Arun comes with a lot of energy. In fact, he joined our film before he found a break as a YouTuber.”

This year, Prakash celebrates completing 20 years as a music composer; his debut film *Veyil* was released in 2006. The composer says that in all these years, the joy of creating hasn’t faded. “It’s akin to a child getting a new toy. That joy will never fade. My problem has always been in the pressure that surrounds it. If you build a brand and create a lot of expectations around it, there will be a lot of pressure. Back when I started, there were no expectations, and so I focussed on the music.” But now there are stars, critics and social media comments that occupy his mind, he says. “All that said, at the end of the day, when I create something, that magic is always there.”

Happy Raj releases in theatres on March 27



Easter sadya
A taste of Kerala’s Syrian Christian traditions comes alive in Chennai this Easter.

From vattayappam and stew, duck mappas curry, chicken fry, pothu olarithiyathu and meen pollichathe to pineapple moru curry, raw mango chilli chammanthi, jackfruit chips, nungu tender coconut pudding and jackfruit payasam, a Nasrani Easter sadya arrives in the city as Chef Kavya Verghese teams up with her mother, Shirin Mammen.

Together, they present a meal rooted in memory, faith, and Kerala’s layered culinary history.

Set as a one-day pop-up on April 5, the Easter Sadya brings both vegetarian and non-vegetarian menus, offering a glimpse into the food traditions of the Syrian Christian (Nasrani) community. While a typical sadya includes sambar, avial, and rice, this version expands to feature community-specific festive dishes.

“It is a blend of Indian and West Asian influences. Our family traces its roots to the early Christian settlers, and over time, the cuisine evolved by adapting to Kerala’s ingredients and culture,” says Shirin.

“We’ve served Kerala dishes before, but this is the first time we’re presenting a sadya as we eat at home,” says Kavya.

The feast will be served on April 5, from 12pm to 2pm and 2pm to 4pm at Mex It Up, Teynampet. For reservations, call 7338706553.

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In artist Ramalingam Muthukrishnan’s exhibition, women take centrestage – their long, sinuous forms that appear both coy yet powerful, exuding an enigmatic power that the artist traces back to traditional Indian sculptures.

The 95 artworks currently on display at Lalit Kala Akademi are drawn from a larger body of work that the artist has been developing since 2013. Rendered in layers of ink and acrylic, the compositions are awash in turquoise blue, vivid teals, and rich magentas, while also reflecting memories of growing up in Chennai. Across these works, free-floating bananas – clustered and peeled – recur as repetitive motifs, often set against the background of a checkered floor where most scenes unfold.

Born in 1957 in Chennai, Ramalingam’s journey as an artist is one marked by profound challenges. Deaf since birth and later diagnosed with Usher Syndrome, which caused tunnel vision and night blindness – his artworks reflect his resilience, perception, and visual depth.

Ramalingam explains that the inkworks are influenced by artist Vijay Mohan, who is known for his charcoal and graphite works. “He was my teacher at the Government College of Arts, Chennai. His work had a great influence on me, which I later picked up in my practice. What may appear simple on canvas carries a strong sense of mathematical proportion – something I absorbed and carried forward in my own practice,” says Ramalingam.



Femme fatale (Left) The compositions are awash in turquoise blue, vivid teals, and rich magentas; (below) the artist. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Bodies in motion

The 95 artworks on display by Ramalingam Muthukrishnan at Lalit Kala Akademi are part of a body of work he has developed since 2013

Despite his challenges, Ramalingam has exhibited widely across India and internationally. “The figurines are also inspired by my travels,” he says. He has also done solo and group shows in Brazil, the US, Russia, the UK, Spain, South Korea, Japan and France. He has been part of prestigious residency programmes, including the Vermont Studio Center (USA), as well as programmes in other parts of the world. He

has also contributed to academia and painting making at Gallaudet University, Washington, DC.



The exhibition is on till March 31, at the Lalit Kala Akademi, from 11am to 7pm. Entry is free.

Roaring loud

Nostalgia, Dhoni buzz and an AR Rahman concert light up Chepauk before IPL 2026



The game is on Chennai Super Kings players with Tamil actor Sivakarthiskeyan during ‘Roar 2026’; (below) AR Rahman. RAGU R

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Chepauk was wrapped in a cricketing time capsule – one where the past and the present met.

The hallowed MA Chidambaram cricket ground has seen thrilling sporting clashes, thanks to it hosting some great India and Chennai Super Kings matches. But ‘Roar 26’ on Sunday was about something different: celebrating what the men in yellow have meant to Chennaites over the years.

Nostalgia stirred

Other cities have cricket franchises. Chennai has an emotion – the Chennai Super Kings. One to which every player returns, years after moving away from cricket, and some after moving on to other franchises. That probably explains why players like Michael Hussey, Joginder Sharma, Murali Vijay, Harbhajan Singh and Dwayne Bravo lined up for a friendly clash with the current squad.

Watching the OG squad in action got every fan go down memory lane. “These players were an integral part of my growing-up years,” says Rakesh M, a fan from Ashok Nagar, “As fans, we now back different players, but when you look back at our franchise’s history, these are the OG stars that started the fandom.” With veteran Muralidharan bowling to the current sensation, Sanju Samson, even as MS Dhoni crouched low behind the stumps, Chennai slipped into a different decade.

‘Chinna Thala’ bonds with ‘Thala’

If the city took to MS Dhoni in a big way, even calling him ‘Thala’ wherever he went, his trusted lieutenant was none other than ‘Chinna Thala’, Suresh Raina.



Chennai’s love affair with Raina – fondly dubbed Mr IPL – has lasted several years and the loud cheers he received at the ground, something that spectators usually reserve only for Dhoni, showcased how much he means to the city.

Along with Matthew Hayden, Raina was inducted into the franchise’s first-ever Hall of Fame. Raina stated, “CSK has the best fans in the world. The crowd here is very knowledgeable – they know their cricket – and have been so supportive over the years.”

A different pitch

Post the cricketing highlights and nostalgia, the stage was set for music. If Asal Kolaar and Paal Dabba got the crowd grooving to popular tracks like ‘Makamishi’ and ‘Paiya Dei’, the Mozart of Madras, AR Rahman, kickstarted with an energetic ‘Yuva’, followed by Shweta Mohan-driven melodies (‘Nenjilile’ and ‘Munbe Vaa’), dedicated to Sanju Samson and Suresh Raina. The loudest cheers were dedicated to the popular ‘Nee Singam Dan’ track, with the cameras panning on MS Dhoni vibing to the track along with his daughter.

Actor Sivakarthiskeyan, who said he was invited as a representative of CSK fans, turned into a fanboy as he excitedly shook hands with Dhoni and posed for photographs. “I live 25 kilometres from Chepauk – on the ECR – but whenever Dhoni walks in, I can hear the noise back home. I am just one of the many fans here who have been inspired by his leadership skills. IPL can be about entertainment, but CSK has always been an emotion and family,” said the actor.

The class of 2026 is new. Prashant Veer, Karthik Sharma and Sarfaraz Khan are some of the exciting new players to watch out for. The faces may have changed, but the emotion and belief remains the same. This IPL 2026, the whistles are back.

